

Deep Dive: Tone and Non-Verbals

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OK. We've talked a little about certain words, what to say and not say when communicating, and how to be concise. Let's talk a little more about tone of voice.

Tone of voice is powerful when it comes to mastering the art of communication. How many times has a situation escalated simply because of the tone of voice? We all – male or female – fall prone to this...betraying our emotions when speaking, or raising our voice when we don't mean to, when we get excited.

There are several ways to work on your tone, but we'll start with one simple one. This is a little exercise we like to call "Bring it down." Meaning, bring down the tone.

To do this, look for situations in your everyday life where something has a strong emotion attached to it and "bring it down" with your communication.

Maybe it's an irate customer on the phone that you can't get to calm down who is taking the opportunity to cuss you out. Instead of hanging up the phone and telling a colleague, "Oh my goodness...that was the *worst* call ever!" Afterwards you might say something calmly to a co-worker like, "The client was visibly upset."

Your toddler just spilled cereal all over the floor 10 minutes before visitors are arriving at your house? Maybe you calmly state "This is an opportunity for us to clean the floor."

Make it a game! Did the car go out on the side of the road? Instead of "I AM SO LATE. I JUST SPENT 45 MINUTES ON THE SIDE OF THE ROAD!" surprise everyone by re-telling it in a cool, calm, collected way. "It wasn't ideal, but we worked out the problem."

You get the point. When you get used to describing the frustrating, unexpected or the latest catastrophe in an even, collected way – even if it doesn't deserve to be...maybe it *was* a disaster – when facing a business situation where you need to dial it back and explain something in a professional tone, you'll have plenty of practice.

There's nothing wrong with emotion, don't get me wrong, but good leaders – skilled communicators, know how to master their emotion and be mindful of their tone. Pat Summitt knew when to raise her voice during a game, but she also knew when to "bring it down" and remain calm.

Next, where are you in the area of body language?

Pat once said, “There is more to being vocal than simply being audible. Especially if you are in a leadership role. You communicate with gestures and body language all the time without realizing it. How you sit in a meeting may send a message. Which chair you choose to sit in might send one also. You can unconsciously project confidence or uncertainty.”

“Generally, I don’t sit on the sidelines. I stand because I feel closer to game. Also, I am aware that my body sends a message from 90 feet away. Good eye contact, a straight posture and a thumbs-up can impart conviction. It's not enough to say, ‘I’m confident.’ You can say those words one hundred times over and over, but no one will buy it if your shoulders are slumped and your voice cracks.”

It turns out, when it comes to success with professional body language, your mother was right: Stand up straight. Don’t fidget. Smile. Give a firm handshake.

One way you can start to learn this is simply by observing others. Have you ever intentionally noticed this before. Who in your office has great body language?

Take some time after this video to jot down a few people who come to mind.

Now, *why* is this? What are they doing that sets them apart?

Maybe they always appear cheerful and confident. Maybe it’s the way they give you their full attention when someone is talking. Maybe they mimic your expressions to show they’re with you when you’re explaining something. It could be a variety of different things. But be intentional. Be on the lookout this week in your office.

There are several books or videos out there that can help you work on your body language, but there are just a few techniques:

- Good posture – not slouching
- Not crossing your arms and looking closed off
- Avoiding any nervous gestures like jiggling your leg, or playing with your jewelry
- Face the person talking to you or lean in when they’re speaking to show interest
- Proper use of your hands – not overdoing it or underdoing it with hand motions

It’s hard to find someone who is a *master* at body language – we all have our unique quirks and traits, so it’s important to figure out what *yours* are. And to do this, you may need a little bit of help. Have you ever watched yourself on a home movie and been horrified? “Do I talk like that? Do I sound like that?” You know who you are.

OK, I thought so!

So you want to do an audit, where you are in the realm of body language. What are your strengths, and what are your weaknesses.

You also want to do the same for your facial expressions. It's easier than ever to see this now in the world of Zoom calls, but you may want to call in a friend or colleague you trust for backup. Tell them you're working on your body language, and would they give you an honest opinion on two things you can improve, or to let you know when your face is betraying you. Ladies, we all know what that face can look like.

And you'd be surprised at how many times our face is communicating something entirely different than what we think it is!

You may have an expressive face, in which case every emotion – concern, frustration, anger, disappointment – is visible on your face. Or you may have the opposite problem – a poker face where there's little to *no* expression on your face and your co-workers can't read you that well. They may think you're displeased when you're not, or unfriendly when you're not. So, start with your face.

You also want to be mindful of your eye contact. This may come very naturally to you, but sometimes women can be naturally shy, perceived as less confident. If you're an introvert – male or female – good eye contact may not come naturally.

A good rule of thumb is to make eye contact 50% of the time when speaking and 70% when listening. That's right – 70% when listening! If you find yourself struggling with eye contact at first, practice noticing the color of people's eyes. Hold eye contact for several seconds, as long as it takes to determine the color of their eyes, then look away if you need to. If looking people in the eyes is too stressful, look at the spot right between their eyes, or their nose. Whatever it takes to start building the habit.

Another technique is trying to read people's expression by looking only at their eyes. You'd be surprised at what someone's eyes can tell you. Do the eyes look sad, tired, excited, nervous? There's a reason they say the eyes are the window to the soul. You'll find that in the process of trying to read people's eyes, you're working two skills – holding eye contact and learning to read other people's body language, which is a key part of emotional intelligence.

So that's several things to work on, but it's worth it. And even the greats still have to work on their body language and overall communication. In her memoir, Pat once wrote that she didn't consider herself starting off to be a very good communicator. "I was pretty hopeless. It's a change I'm proud to have made, and it's the way in which I've grown the most as a coach."

With all that in mind, how will you grow?